PYTHON FOR DATA SCIENCE · LESSON 10 OF 29

Comprehensions, Lambda, map/filter and Generators

Write compact, readable Python. Learn list, set and dict comprehensions, lambda with sorted/min/max, map and filter, any and all, generators and itertools, and when plain loops or pandas are the better choice.

Python class 8 | Python 3.13 | Beginner | 100 min

By the end of this lesson you can

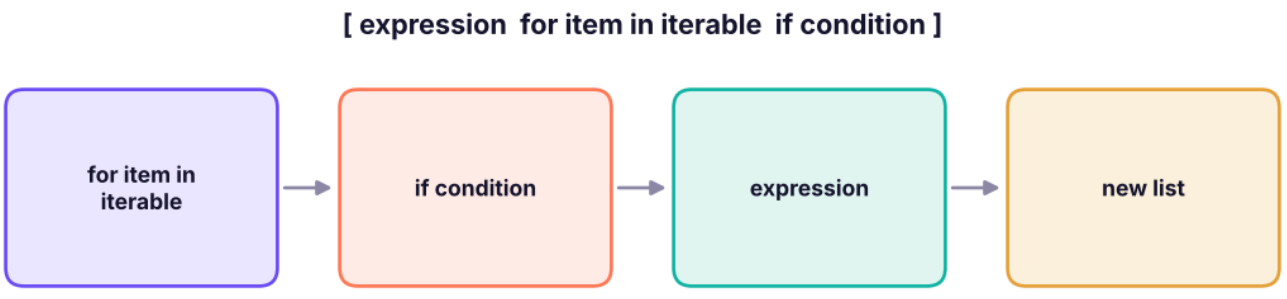
- Write list, set and dictionary comprehensions with conditions and nesting
- Use lambda functions with sorted, min, max, map and filter
- Use any, all, zip, enumerate and sum with generator expressions
- Explain lazy evaluation and write generator functions with yield
- Use itertools and functools for common patterns and know when not to be clever

Datasets used

`superstore_sales.csv`

List comprehensions

A **comprehension** builds a collection from another in one expression: `[expression for item in iterable if condition]`.



A comprehension reads like the sentence "give me X for each item, if the condition holds".

Python

```
nums = [1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6]
squares = [n * n for n in nums]
evens = [n for n in nums if n % 2 == 0]
labels = ["even" if n % 2 == 0 else "odd" for n in nums]          # if/else goes BEFORE the
for
loop_version = []
for n in nums:
    if n % 2 == 0: loop_version.append(n * n)
print(squares, evens, labels, [n * n for n in nums if n % 2 == 0] == loop_version)
```

OUTPUT

```
[1, 4, 9, 16, 25, 36] [2, 4, 6] ['odd', 'even', 'odd', 'even', 'odd', 'even'] True
```

Python

```
words = ["  Pune ", "delhi", " KOCHI", "goa  "]
print([w.strip().title() for w in words])
print([(x, y) for x in (1, 2) for y in ("a", "b")])            # two loops
matrix = [[1, 2, 3], [4, 5, 6]]
print([v for row in matrix for v in row], [list(col) for col in zip(*matrix)])    #
flatten, transpose
```

OUTPUT

```
['Pune', 'Delhi', 'Kochi', 'Goa']
[(1, 'a'), (1, 'b'), (2, 'a'), (2, 'b')]
[1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6] [[1, 4], [2, 5], [3, 6]]
```

Set and dictionary comprehensions

Python

```
print({len(w) for w in ["tea", "cup", "mug", "plate"]})                          # set
prices = {"Pen": 10, "Notebook": 45, "Stapler": 180}
print({k: round(v * 1.18, 2) for k, v in prices.items()})
# dict
print({k: v for k, v in prices.items() if v > 20}, {c: ord(c) for c in "abc"})
```

OUTPUT

```
{3, 5}
{'Pen': 11.8, 'Notebook': 53.1, 'Stapler': 212.4}
{'Notebook': 45, 'Stapler': 180} {'a': 97, 'b': 98, 'c': 99}
```

TIP **Keep it readable**

If a comprehension needs more than one condition or nested level, or does not fit comfortably on one or two lines, use a normal loop or a helper function. Clever is not the goal; clear is.

Lambda functions

A **lambda** is a small anonymous function: `lambda args: expression`.

Python

```
sq = lambda x: x * x                          # fine to learn with, but def is better for named functions
print(sq(5), (lambda a, b: a + b)(2, 3))
people = [("Asha", 29, 62000), ("Ravi", 35, 88000), ("Meera", 31, 75000)]
print(sorted(people, key=lambda p: p[2], reverse=True))        # sort by salary
print(min(people, key=lambda p: p[1]), max(people, key=lambda p: p[2])[0])
print(sorted(["banana", "kiwi", "apple", "fig"], key=lambda w: (len(w), w)))    # sort by length, then alphabet
```

OUTPUT

```
25 5
[('Ravi', 35, 88000), ('Meera', 31, 75000), ('Asha', 29, 62000)]
('Asha', 29, 62000) Ravi
['fig', 'kiwi', 'apple', 'banana']
```

Lambdas shine as the `key=` for `sorted`, `min`, `max`, and in `df.apply`.

map, filter, any, all

Python

```
nums = [3, 8, 12, 5, 20]
print(list(map(lambda x: x * 2, nums)), list(map(str, nums)), list(filter(lambda x: x > 6, nums)))
print([x * 2 for x in nums], [x for x in nums if x > 6])        # comprehensions say the same thing
print(any(n > 15 for n in nums), all(n > 0 for n in nums), sum(1 for n in nums if n % 2 == 0))
print(list(zip(["a", "b", "c"], [1, 2, 3])), dict(zip("abc", range(3))), list(enumerate("xyz", 1)))
```

OUTPUT

```
[6, 16, 24, 10, 40] ['3', '8', '12', '5', '20'] [8, 12, 20]
[6, 16, 24, 10, 40] [8, 12, 20]
True True 3
[('a', 1), ('b', 2), ('c', 3)] {'a': 0, 'b': 1, 'c': 2} [(1, 'x'), (2, 'y'), (3,
'z')]
```

`map` and `filter` return lazy iterators; wrap with `list(...)`. Most Python programmers prefer comprehensions, but you will see both.

Generators: lazy sequences

A **generator expression** uses parentheses and produces items one at a time, without building the whole list in memory.

Python

```python
import sys
big_list = [n * n for n in range(1_000_000)]
big_gen = (n * n for n in range(1_000_000))
print(sys.getsizeof(big_list) // 1000, "KB list vs", sys.getsizeof(big_gen), "bytes
generator")
print(sum(n * n for n in range(1_000_000)), next(iter(big_gen)), next(big_gen))
```

OUTPUT

```
8448 KB list vs 200 bytes generator
333332833333500000 0 1
```

A **generator function** uses `yield`. It pauses at each `yield` and resumes on the next request:

Python

```python
def countdown(n):
    while n > 0:
        yield n
        n -= 1
print(list(countdown(5)))
def read_in_batches(items, size):
    for i in range(0, len(items), size):
        yield items[i:i + size]
for batch in read_in_batches(list(range(10)), 4): print(batch)
def fib():
    a, b = 0, 1
    while True:                  # infinite sequence, safe because it is lazy
        yield a
        a, b = b, a + b
import itertools
print(list(itertools.islice(fib(), 12)))
```

OUTPUT

```
[5, 4, 3, 2, 1]
[0, 1, 2, 3]
[4, 5, 6, 7]
[8, 9]
[0, 1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21, 34, 55, 89]
```

Generators are how Python reads large files line by line, streams API pages and chains pipeline steps with constant memory. Once consumed, a generator is empty:

Python

```python
g = (x for x in range(3))
print(list(g), list(g))
```

OUTPUT

```
[0, 1, 2] []
```

itertools and functools highlights

Python

```
import itertools, functools, operator
from collections import Counter
print(list(itertools.chain([1, 2], [3], [4, 5])), list(itertools.combinations("ABC", 2)),
list(itertools.product("AB", [0, 1])))
print(list(itertools.accumulate([10, 20, 5, 15])), functools.reduce(operator.mul, [1, 2, 3,
4, 5]))
for key, grp in itertools.groupby(sorted(["ant", "bee", "ape", "bat"]), key=lambda w:
w[0]): print(key, list(grp))
@functools.lru_cache(maxsize=None)              # memoise a function: remember results of
earlier calls
def slow_square(n): return n * n
print([slow_square(n) for n in (4, 4, 5, 4)], slow_square.cache_info())
```

OUTPUT

```
[1, 2, 3, 4, 5] [('A', 'B'), ('A', 'C'), ('B', 'C')] [('A', 0), ('A', 1), ('B', 0),
('B', 1)]
[10, 30, 35, 50] 120
a ['ant', 'ape']
b ['bat', 'bee']
[16, 16, 25, 16] CacheInfo(hits=2, misses=2, maxsize=None, currsize=2)
```

Real data examples

Python

```
import pandas as pd
s = pd.read_csv("superstore_sales.csv", parse_dates=["order_date"])
regions = sorted(s["region"].unique())
print({r: round(float(s.loc[s.region == r, "sales"].sum()) / 1e6, 1) for r in regions})
# dict comprehension
top_customers = [c for c, n in s["customer_id"].value_counts().items() if n ⩾ 18][:5]
print(top_customers, len([c for c, n in s["customer_id"].value_counts().items() if n ⩾
18]))
rows = s.head(4)[["order_id", "sales", "profit"]].to_dict("records")
print([{**r, "margin": round(100 * r["profit"] / r["sales"], 1)} for r in rows])
# enrich records
print(sorted(s["category"].unique(), key=lambda c: -s.loc[s.category == c, "sales"].sum()))
# sort by a computed key
```

OUTPUT

```
{'East': 46.5, 'North': 49.0, 'South': 54.0, 'West': 52.0}
['C0719', 'C0149', 'C0126', 'C0384', 'C0257'] 21
```

```
[{'order_id': 'IN-2023-00001', 'sales': 36000.0, 'profit': 3472.55, 'margin': 9.6},
{'order_id': 'IN-2023-00001', 'sales': 3850.0, 'profit': 1169.54, 'margin': 30.4},
{'order_id': 'IN-2023-00001', 'sales': 62080.0, 'profit': 6044.47, 'margin': 9.7},
{'order_id': 'IN-2023-00002', 'sales': 5216.0, 'profit': 450.16, 'margin': 8.6}]
['Technology', 'Furniture', 'Office Supplies']
```

Which tool when?

Situation	Prefer
Transform or filter a small list	List comprehension
Sort by a rule	`sorted(..., key=lambda ...)`
Huge or streaming data	Generator (expression or function)
Table columns	Vectorised pandas (`df["a"] * 2` , `np.where`), not comprehensions
Multi-step logic with side effects	Plain `for` loop
Reuse the same transformation	Named `def` function

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- `[expr for x in it if cond]` builds a list; `{…}` builds sets and dicts; the conditional expression (`a if c else b`) comes before `for` .
- `lambda` is an anonymous one-expression function, mostly used as `key=` and in `apply` .
- `map` / `filter` are lazy; comprehensions are usually clearer. `any` , `all` , `sum` work well with generator expressions.
- Generators (`( … )` or `yield`) produce values lazily, use almost no memory and can be infinite; they can be consumed only once.
- `itertools` and `functools` (`chain` , `combinations` , `groupby` , `lru_cache` , `reduce`) cover many patterns; keep code readable and vectorise table work.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. What does `[x * 2 for x in range(4) if x != 2]` give?

A [0, 2, 4, 6]

B [0, 2, 6]

C [0, 4, 6]

D [2, 6]

Answer: B. Item 2 is filtered out before doubling.

2. Where does an `if ... else` go in a comprehension?

A After the for

B Before the for, as part of the expression

C It is not allowed

D At the end

Answer: B. `[a if cond else b for x in it]`.

3. What is the main advantage of a generator expression over a list comprehension?

A It is faster to type

B It is lazy and uses very little memory

C It supports indexing

D It can be reused

Answer: B. Values are produced one at a time.

4. What does `sorted(people, key=lambda p: p[2])` do?

A Sorts by the first item

B Sorts by the third item of each tuple

C Reverses the list

D Raises an error

Answer: B. `key` supplies the sort value.

5. What happens when you iterate a generator twice?

A It restarts

B The second pass is empty because it was consumed

C It raises an error

D It doubles the values

Answer: B. Create a new generator or use a list.

6. Which is usually best for adding a column to a DataFrame?

A A for loop over rows

B A vectorised column operation

C A generator

D A lambda inside a nested loop

Answer: B. Vectorised code is shorter and much faster.

EXERCISE

Comprehension problems

(1) List the squares of odd numbers from 1 to 20. (2) Build a dictionary from words to their lengths for words longer than 3 letters. (3) Flatten `[[1,2],[3],[4,5,6]]`. (4) Sort `["pune","Delhi","goa","Kochi"]` case-insensitively. (5) Write a generator that yields only the primes below 50. (6) From the Superstore data, list sub-categories with total profit below zero.

Show solution (worked answer)

Python

```
print([n * n for n in range(1, 21) if n % 2])
print({w: len(w) for w in ["tea", "plate", "mug", "bottle"] if len(w) > 3})
print([v for part in [[1, 2], [3], [4, 5, 6]] for v in part])
print(sorted(["pune", "Delhi", "goa", "Kochi"], key=str.lower))
def primes(limit):
    for n in range(2, limit):
        if all(n % d for d in range(2, int(n ** 0.5) + 1)): yield n
print(list(primes(50)))
loss = s.groupby("sub_category")["profit"].sum()
print(list(loss[loss < 0].index))
```

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: List comprehension vs generator expression? Both iterate with the same syntax; the list builds everything now in memory, the generator yields lazily and is single-use.

Q: When should you avoid a comprehension? When logic needs several statements, side effects, or deep nesting; readability matters more than brevity.

Q: What does `yield` do? It turns a function into a generator: the function pauses, hands back a value, and resumes where it left off on the next call.

Q: How do you flatten a list of lists? `[x for sub in lists for x in sub]` or `itertools.chain.from_iterable(lists)`.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.